Networking for innovation

No person exists on their own, and no organization operates in isolation. Innovation has always been a multiplayer game, and in a world of "open innovation," where not all the smart people work for you, organizations are increasingly turning to networks to help them manage innovation.

TIP

COMBINE IDEAS

Once you and your innovators have been exposed to new ideas and concepts from other areas of your industry, or even other industries altogether, you can experiment to generate new concepts.

Maximizing resources

The benefits of innovation networks can be substantial. For small firms, the limiting factor is often that they are separated from developments in the wider market—they lack the overview of market intelligence a larger firm can access. Linking up in networks means they can tap into each other's resources, ideas, and knowledge. However, even larger firms are increasingly realizing how important a resource this can be, and adopting innovation network tactics accordingly. Innovation networks allow you to share resources and reduce potential risks of developing new products and processes. They give you diversity of perspectives, and access to knowledge sets and experience outside those in your organization.

ASK YOURSELF... HOW DEVELOPED IS YOUR CAPACITY FOR NETWORKING?

- Do I have links with a wide range of outside sources of knowledge—universities, research centers, and specialized agencies?
- Do I practice "open innovation" by using rich and widespread networks of contacts from whom I get a constant flow of challenging ideas?
- Does my approach to supply management permit "strategic dalliances"?
- Do I have contacts within the research and technology community?
- Do I recognize users as a source of new ideas and try to co-evolve new products and services with them?